

Beauty



It was not only virtues that Socrates and his followers sought to define. One of his seemingly simple questions was: ‘What is beauty?’ – the starting point for the field of aesthetics (see [Aesthetics](#)). As with virtue, it is easier to recognize individual instances of beautiful things than to pin down beauty itself.

For the classical Greeks, however, certain common characteristics could be identified, especially proportion, symmetry, balance and harmony. These reflected both an interest in mathematics that had its origins in Pythagoras’s

analysis of musical harmony and proportion, and the idea of the Golden Mean of Aristotle's ethics (see [Ethics and the Golden Mean](#)). But in seeking a definition for beauty, other questions arose: are these criteria universal, or is beauty in the eye of the beholder and simply a matter of taste? Is something beautiful because we find it beautiful, or is there something inherent that makes it beautiful? And is there a difference between the beauty we see in nature and the man-made beauty of a work of art?